

Chapter | 15 | Presentations



>>> Chapter Objectives

In this chapter, students will

- Learn the importance of oral presentations to their career success
- Be introduced to guidelines for preparing and delivering effective presentations
- Learn how to use presentation graphics effectively
- Be introduced to poster sessions that share the results of research
- Read advice for overcoming nervousness about presentations
- Read and analyze a model presentation

As the leader of the “Commute Group” in the Boston branch, Larry Beeman was responsible for preparing the report on the branch’s experiment with telecommuting. (See the Chapter 4 Communication Challenge, pages 106–108.) Because of the interest generated by the project, Larry was invited to present information about the project and answer questions about it at a meeting of all of the managers of M-Global’s domestic branches. After arriving at the corporate headquarters in Baltimore, Larry entered the elevator and pushed the button for the executive floor. Just as the door was about to close, a woman carrying a briefcase squeezed into the elevator. She noticed that the button for her floor had already been pushed and asked him, “Are you here for the branch managers’ meeting?”

Larry responded, “Yes, as a matter of fact, I’m going to be presenting.”

“What are you going to be talking about?” she asked.

“I’m from the Boston branch. I’m going to be talking about how the lessons we learned when we started our telecommuting project can be useful to other branches that are interested in trying it.”

“I’m looking forward to hearing about that,” she said as the elevator door opened on their floor.

As the woman walked down the hall and was greeted with “Good Morning, Ms. McDuff!” “Good morning, Jeannie!” Larry realized that he had been in the elevator with Jeannie McDuff, Vice President of Domestic Operations and the granddaughter of the company’s founder. He was glad that he had practiced an elevator

speech, a summary of his talk that is short enough to be delivered during an elevator ride.

Your career will present you with many opportunities for oral presentations, both formal and informal. At the time they arise, however, you may not consider them to be “opportunities.” They may seem to loom on the horizon as stressful obstacles. That response is normal. The purpose of this chapter is to provide the tools to help you create oral presentations that will contribute to your self-esteem and career success. There are guidelines for preparation and delivery of formal presentations, guidelines for more casual poster sessions, techniques for dealing with anxiety, and an example of a technical presentation. The chapter also addresses the related topic of running effective meetings.

The entire chapter is based on one simple principle: *Almost anyone can become an excellent speaker.* Put aside the myth that competent speakers are born with the talent—that “Either they have it or they don’t.” Certainly some people have more natural talent at thinking on their feet or have a more resonant voice, but success at speaking can come to all speakers, whatever their talent, if they follow the 3 Ps:

Step 1: Prepare carefully.

Step 2: Practice often.

Step 3: Perform with enthusiasm.

These steps form the foundation for all specific guidelines that follow. Before presenting these guidelines, this chapter examines specific ways that formal and informal presentations become part of your professional life.

>>> Presentations and Your Career

Some oral presentations you will choose to give; others will be “command performances” thrust upon you. Using M-Global, Inc., as a backdrop, the following examples present some realistic situations in which the ability to speak well can lead to success for you and your organization:

- **Getting hired:** As a job applicant with a business degree, you are asked to present several M-Global managers with a 10-minute summary of your education, previous experience, and career goals.

- **Getting customers:** As coordinator of an M-Global proposal team, you have just been informed that M-Global made the “short list” of companies bidding on a contract to manage a large construction project. You and your three team members must deliver a 20-minute oral presentation that highlights the written proposal. To be given in five days at the client’s office in Grand Rapids, Michigan, the presentation begins and ends with comments by you in your role as coordinator. Your three colleagues each contribute a 5-minute talk.
- **Keeping customers:** As a field engineer at M-Global’s St. Louis office, you recently submitted a report on your evaluation of a 50-year-old dam in the Ozarks. Now your clients, the commissioners of the county that owns the dam, have asked you to attend their monthly meeting to present an overview of your findings and respond to questions.
- **Contributing to your profession:** As a laboratory supervisor for M-Global, you belong to a professional society that meets yearly to discuss issues in your field. This year you have been asked to deliver a 15-minute presentation on new procedures for testing toxic waste samples in the laboratory.
- **Contributing to your community:** As an environmental scientist at M-Global’s San Francisco office, you have been asked to speak at the quarterly meeting of OceanSave, an activist environmental organization. The organization suggests that you speak for half an hour on environmental threats to aquatic life. You accept the invitation because you know that M-Global management encourages such community service.
- **Getting promoted:** As an employee about to be considered for promotion, you are evaluated on your ability to present information orally. Supervisors will discuss whether they themselves have heard—or heard from others—about your effective presentations to colleagues, clients, or community representatives.

As you can see from this list, oral presentations are defined quite broadly. Usually they can be classified according to criteria such as the following:

1. **Format:** From informal question/answer sessions to formal speeches
2. **Length:** From several-minute overviews to long sessions of an hour or more
3. **Number of presenters:** From solo performances to team presentations
4. **Content:** From a few highlights to detailed coverage

Throughout your career, you will speak to different-sized groups, on diverse topics, and in varied formats. The next two sections provide some common guidelines on preparation, delivery, and graphics.

>>> Guidelines for Preparation and Delivery

The goal of most oral presentations is quite simple: You must present a few basic points, in a fairly brief time, to an interested but usually impatient audience. Simplicity, brevity, and interest are the keys to success. If you deliver what *you* expect when *you* hear a speech, then you will give good presentations yourself.

Although the guidelines here apply to any presentation, they relate best to those that precede or follow a written report, proposal, memo, or letter. Few career presentations are isolated from written work. With this connection in mind, note that there are many similarities between the guidelines for good speaking and those for good writing covered in earlier chapters—especially the importance of analyzing the needs of the audience.

>> **Presentation Guideline 1: Know Your Listeners**

The following features are common to most listeners:

- They cannot “rewind the tape” of your presentation, as opposed to the way they can skip back and forth through the text of a report.
- They are impatient after the first few minutes, particularly if they do not know where a speech is going.
- They will daydream and often must have their attention brought back to the matter at hand (expect a 30-second attention span).
- They have heard so many disappointing presentations that they might not have high expectations for yours.

To respond to these realities, you must learn as much as possible about your listeners. For example, you can (1) consider what you already know about your audience, (2) talk with colleagues who have spoken to the same group, and (3) find out which listeners make the decisions.

Most important, make sure not to talk over anyone’s head. If there are several levels of technical expertise represented by the group, find the lowest common denominator and decrease the technical level of your presentation accordingly. Remember—decision makers are often the ones without current technical experience. They may want only highlights; later, they can review written documents for details or solicit more technical information during the question-and-answer session after you speak.

>> **Presentation Guideline 2: Use the Preacher’s Maxim**

The well-known preacher’s maxim goes like this:

First you tell ’em what you’re gonna tell ’em, then you tell ’em, and then you tell ’em what you told ’em.

Why should most speakers follow this plan? Because it gives the speech a simple three-part structure that most listeners can grasp easily. Following is how your speech should be organized (note that it corresponds to the ABC format used throughout this text for writing). The beginning of the presentation, or the abstract, should (1) get the listeners’ interest (with an anecdote, a statistic, or other technique), (2) state the exact purpose of



Orange Line Media/Shutterstock

the speech, and (3) list the main points you will cover. Do not try the patience of your audience with an extended introduction—use no more than a minute.

Example: “Last year, Jones Engineering had 56 percent more field accidents than the year before. This morning, I’ll examine a proposed safety plan that aims to solve this problem. My presentation will focus on three main benefits of the new plan: lower insurance premiums, less lost time from accidents, and better morale among the employees.”

In the body of your presentation, discuss the points mentioned briefly in the introduction, in the same order that they were mentioned. Provide the kinds of obvious transitions that help your listeners stay on track.

Example: “The final benefit of the new safety plan will be improved morale among the field workers at all our job sites.”

At the end of your presentation, the conclusion, review the main ideas covered in the body of the speech and specify actions you want to occur as a result of your presentation.

Example: “Jones Engineering can benefit from this new safety plan in three main ways....

If Jones implements the new plan next month, I believe you will see a dramatic reduction in on-site accidents during the second half of the year.”

ABC Format: Presentations

- **ABSTRACT:** Subject of presentation and overview of key topics
- **BODY:** Key topics in same order as presented in abstract
- **CONCLUSION:** Review of main ideas discussed in presentation and suggestion of how audience members should respond

This simple three-part plan for all presentations gives listeners the handle they need to understand your speech. First, there is a clear *road map* in the introduction so that they know what lies ahead in the rest of the speech. Second, there is an organized pattern in the body, with clear transitions between points. And third, there is a strong finish that brings the audience back full circle to the main thrust of the presentation.

>> Presentation Guideline 3: Stick to a Few Main Points

Our short-term memory holds a limited number of items. It follows that listeners are most attentive to speeches organized around a few major points. In fact, a good argument can be made for organizing information in groups of threes whenever possible. For reasons that are not totally understood, listeners seem to remember groups of three items more than they do any other size groupings—perhaps because

- The number is simple
- It parallels the overall three-part structure of most speeches and documents (beginning, middle, end)
- Many good speakers have used triads (Winston Churchill’s “Blood, sweat, and tears,” Caesar’s “I came, I saw, I conquered,” etc.)

Whatever the reason, groupings of three make your speech more memorable to the audience.

>> Presentation Guideline 4: Put Your Outline on Cards or Paper

The best presentations are *extemporaneous*, meaning the speaker shows great familiarity with the material but uses notes for occasional reference. Avoid extremes of (1) reading a speech verbatim, which many listeners consider the ultimate insult, or (2) memorizing a speech, which can make your presentation seem somewhat wooden and artificial.

Ironically, you appear more natural if you refer to notes during a presentation. Such extemporaneous speaking allows you to make last-minute changes in phrasing and emphasis that may improve delivery, rather than locking you into specific phrasing that is memorized or written out word for word. If you know your presentation information well, speaking extemporaneously also allows you to adjust your speech slightly in response to your audience's reactions, clarifying concepts that seem to confuse them or emphasizing information that they seem especially interested in.

Depending on your personal preference, you may choose to write speech notes on (1) index cards, (2) a sheet or two of paper, or (3) the "Notes View" available with most presentation software. The main advantages and disadvantages of each are presented in the list that follows.

1. Notes on Cards (3-by-5-inch or 4-by-6-inch cards)

Advantages

- ◆ Are easy to carry in a shirt pocket, coat, or purse
- ◆ Provide a way to organize points, through ordering of cards
- ◆ Can lead to smooth delivery in that each card contains only one or two points
- ◆ Can be held in one hand, allowing you to move away from lectern while speaking

Disadvantages

- ◆ Keep you from viewing outline of entire speech
- ◆ Require that you flip through cards repeatedly in speech
- ◆ Can limit use of gestures with hands
- ◆ Can cause confusion if they are not in correct order

2. Notes on Sheets of Paper

Advantages

- ◆ Help you quickly view outline of entire speech
- ◆ Leave your hands free to use gestures
- ◆ Are less obvious than note cards, for no flipping is needed

Disadvantages

- ◆ Tend to tie you to lectern, where the sheets lie
- ◆ May cause slipups in delivery if you lose your place on the page

3. Printout of "Notes View" pages from presentation software

Advantages

- ◆ Reminds you of text to accompany each slide
- ◆ Can lead to smooth delivery in that each page contains only a few points
- ◆ Can include special notes and reminders about information to be highlighted
- ◆ Can be used as record of the presentation

Disadvantages

- ◆ Requires you to flip pages with each new slide
- ◆ Tends to tie you to lectern, where the sheets lie
- ◆ Can cause confusion if they are not in correct order

>> Presentation Guideline 5: Practice, Practice, Practice

Many speakers prepare a well-organized speech but then fail to add the essential ingredient: practice. Constant practice distinguishes superior presentations from mediocre ones. It also helps eliminate the nervousness that most speakers feel at one time or another.

In practicing your presentation, make use of four main techniques, listed here from least to most effective:

- **Practice before a mirror:** This old-fashioned approach allows you to hear and see yourself in action. The drawback, of course, is that it is difficult to evaluate your own performance while you are speaking. Nevertheless, such run-throughs definitely make you more comfortable with the material.
- **Use of an audio recording:** Most presenters have access to an audio recorder, so this approach is quite practical. The portability of electronics allows you to practice almost anywhere. Although recording a presentation does not improve gestures, it helps you discover and eliminate verbal distractions such as *filler words* (e.g., *uhhhh*, *um*, *ya know*).
- **Use of video recording:** This practice technique allows you to see and hear yourself as others do. Your careful review of the recording, particularly when done with another qualified observer, can help you identify and eliminate problems with posture, eye contact, vocal patterns, and gestures. At first it can be a chilling experience, but you soon get over the awkwardness of seeing yourself on the screen.
- **Use of live audience:** Groups of your colleagues, friends, or family—simulating a real audience—can provide the kinds of responses that approximate those of a real audience. In setting up this type of practice session, however, make certain that observers understand the criteria for a good presentation and are prepared to give an honest and forthright critique.

>> Presentation Guideline 6: Speak Vigorously and Deliberately

Vigorously means with enthusiasm; *deliberately* means with care, attention, and appropriate emphasis on words and phrases. The importance of this guideline becomes clear when you think back to how you felt during the last speech you heard. At the very least, you expected the speaker to show interest in the subject and demonstrate enthusiasm. Good information is not enough—you must arouse the interest of the listeners.

You may wonder, “How much enthusiasm is enough?” The best way to answer this question is to hear or (preferably) watch yourself on a recording. Your delivery should incorporate just enough enthusiasm so that it sounds and looks a bit unnatural to you. Few if any listeners ever complain about a speech being too enthusiastic or a speaker being too energetic, but many people complain about dull speakers who fail to show that they themselves are excited about the topic. Remember—every presentation is, in a sense, *show time*.

>> Presentation Guideline 7: Avoid Filler Words

Avoiding filler words presents a tremendous challenge to most speakers. When they think about what comes next or encounter a break in the speech, they may tend to fill the gap with filler words and phrases such as these:

uhhhhh ...

ya know ...

OK ...

well ... uh ...

like ...

I mean ...

umm ...

These gap fillers are a bit like spelling errors in written work: Once your listeners find a few, they start looking for more and are distracted from your presentation. To eliminate such distractions, follow these three steps:

Step 1: Use pauses to your advantage. Short gaps or pauses inform the listener that you are shifting from one point to another. In signaling a transition, a pause serves to draw attention to the point you make right after the pause. Note how listeners look at you when you pause. Do *not* fill these strategic pauses with filler words.

Step 2: Practice with a recorder. A recording is brutally honest: When you play it back, you become instantly aware of fillers that occur more than once or twice. Keep a tally sheet of the fillers you use and their frequency. Your goal is to reduce this frequency with every practice session.

Step 3: Ask for help from others. After working with audio recorders in Step 2, give your speech to an individual who has been instructed to stop you after each filler. This technique gives immediate reinforcement.

>> Presentation Guideline 8: Use Rhetorical Questions

Enthusiasm, of course, is your best delivery technique for capturing the attention of the audience. Another technique is the use of rhetorical questions at pivotal points in your presentation.

Rhetorical questions are those you ask to get listeners thinking about a topic, not those that you would expect them to answer out loud. They prod listeners to think about your point and set up an expectation that important information follows. Also, they break the monotony of standard declarative sentence patterns. One example of a rhetorical question could be used by a computer salesperson in proposing a purchase by one of M-Global's small offices:

Example: I've discussed the three main advantages that a centralized copy center would provide your office staff. But is this an approach that you can afford at this point in the company's growth?

Next the speaker could follow the question with remarks supporting the position that the system is affordable.

“What if” scenarios provide another way to introduce rhetorical questions. They gain listeners’ attention by having them envision a situation that might occur. For example, a safety engineer could use this kind of rhetorical question in proposing M-Global’s asbestos-removal services to a regional bank:

Example: What if you repossessed a building that contained dangerous levels of asbestos? Do you think that your bank would then be liable for removing all the asbestos?

Again, the question pattern heightens listener interest.

Rhetorical questions do not come naturally. You must make a conscious effort to insert them at points when it is most important to gain or redirect the attention of the audience. Three particularly effective uses follow:

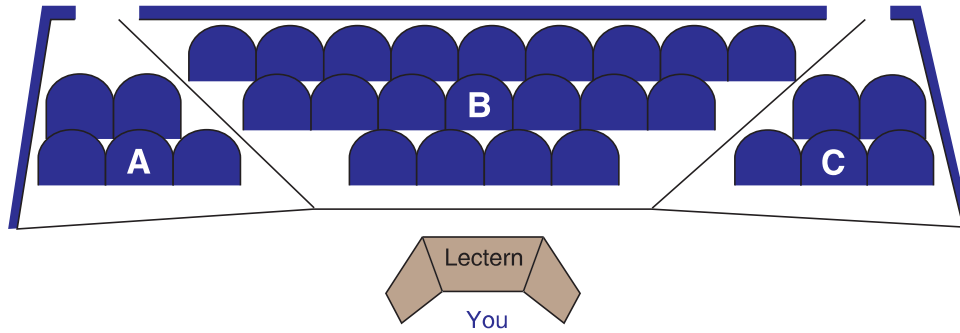
1. **As a grabber at the beginning of a speech:** “Have you ever wondered how you might improve the control and distribution of your internal documents?”
2. **As a transition between major points:** “We’ve seen that a content management system can improve the control of internal documents, but will it simplify the access to those documents by your employees?”
3. **As an attention getter right before your conclusion:** “Now that we’ve examined the features of a content management system, what’s the next step you should make at M-Global?”

>> Presentation Guideline 9: Maintain Eye Contact

Your main goal—always—is to keep listeners interested in what you are saying. This goal requires that you maintain control, using whatever techniques possible to direct the attention of the audience. Frequent eye contact is one good strategy.

The simple truth is that listeners pay closer attention to what you are saying when you look at them. Think how you react when a speaker makes constant eye contact with you. If you are like most people, you feel as if the speaker is speaking to you personally—even if there are 100 people in the audience. Also, you tend to feel more obligated to listen when you know that the speaker’s eyes will be meeting yours throughout the presentation. Following are some ways you can make eye contact a natural part of your own strategy for effective oral presentations:

- **With audiences of about 30 or less:** Make regular eye contact with everyone in the room. Be particularly careful not to ignore members of the audience who are seated to your far right and far left (Figure 15–1). Many speakers tend to focus on the listeners in Section B. Instead, make wide sweeps so that listeners in Sections A and C get equal attention.
- **With large audiences:** There may be too many people or a room too large for you to make individual eye contact with all listeners. In this case, focus on just a few people in all three sections of the audience, as noted in Figure 15–1. This approach gives the appearance that you are making eye contact with the entire audience.



■ **Figure 15-1** ■
Audience sections

■ **With any size audience:** Occasionally, look away from the audience—either to your notes or toward a part of the room where there are no faces looking back. In this way, you avoid the appearance of staring too intensely at your audience. Also, these breaks give you the chance to collect your thoughts or check your notes.

>> **Presentation Guideline 10: Use Appropriate Gestures and Posture**

Speaking is only one part of giving a speech; another is adopting appropriate posture and using gestures that reinforce what you are saying. Note that good speakers are much more than “talking heads” before a lectern. Instead, they

1. Use their hands and fingers to emphasize major points
2. Stand straight, without leaning on or gripping the lectern
3. Step out from behind the lectern on occasion, to decrease the distance between them and the audience
4. Point toward visuals on screens or charts, without losing eye contact with the audience

The audience judges you by what you say and what they see, a fact that again makes video recording a crucial part of your preparation. With work on this facet of your presentation, you can avoid problems like keeping your hands constantly in your pockets, rattling change (remove pocket change and keys beforehand), tapping a pencil, scratching nervously, slouching over a lectern, and shifting from foot to foot.

Presentation Guidelines

- Know your listeners
- Use the preacher’s maxim
- Stick to a few main points
- Put your outline on cards or paper
- Practice, practice, practice
- Speak vigorously and deliberately
- Avoid filler words
- Use rhetorical questions
- Maintain eye contact
- Use appropriate gestures and posture



>>> Guidelines for Presentation Graphics

More than ever before, listeners expect good graphics during oral presentations. Much like gestures, graphics transform the words of your presentation into true communication with the audience. When you display graphics and text during a presentation, they should illustrate and clarify your speech. Therefore, we include displayed text in our discussion of graphics in this section.

>> Presentation Graphics Guideline 1: Discover Listener Preferences

Some professionals prefer simple speech graphics, such as flip charts or transparencies. Others prefer more sophisticated presentations, such as animations, audio, or video. Some audiences prefer simple outlines, some may prefer charts and graphs, and still others may prefer full-color images.

Your listeners are usually willing to indicate their preferences when you call on them. Contact the audience ahead of time and make some inquiries. Also ask for information about the room in which you will be speaking and about the presentation technology that will be available to you. If possible, request a setting that allows you to make best use of your graphics choice. If you have no control over the setting, then choose graphics that best fit the constraints. Details about lighting, wall space, projection technology, and chair configuration can greatly influence your selection.

>> Presentation Graphics Guideline 2: Match the Graphics to the Content

Plan graphics while you prepare the text so that the final presentation seems fluid. Remember that everything you project on a screen or present on a flip chart should support and enhance your presentation. Choose images and words that help your reader focus on what you are saying.

>> Presentation Graphics Guideline 3: Keep the Message Simple

When Edward Tufte critiqued PowerPoint slides in *The Cognitive Style of PowerPoint*, one of the problems he pointed to was the use of too many graphic elements on each slide, the equivalent of the *chartjunk* that he had argued against in his earlier studies of graphics¹ (see Chapter 13). Some basic design guidelines apply, whether you are using posters, overhead transparencies, or computer-aided graphics such as PowerPoint.

- Use few words, emphasizing just one idea on each frame.

Note: A common PowerPoint mistake is the use of too much text, which then gets read to the audience by the speaker.

- Use more white space, perhaps as much as 60%–70% per frame.
- Use landscape format more often than portrait, especially because it is the preferred default setting for most presentation software.
- Use sans-serif large print, from 14 pt. to 18 pt. minimum for text to 48 pt. for titles.

¹E. R. Tufte. (2003). *The cognitive style of PowerPoint*. Cheshire, CT: Graphics Press.

Your goal should be to create graphics that are seen easily from anywhere in the room and that complement—but do not overpower—your presentation.

You should also use audio and video elements sparingly. Most presentation software programs include sound effects to accompany slide changes or the appearance of text or images. These are distracting and annoying, and should be avoided. You should also use video carefully. For example, during a presentation on automobile safety, the presenter included an animation of a crash that ran in a constant loop throughout her presentation. This made it difficult for the audience to focus on the findings of the presenter's study. However, if the presenter had allowed the video to run once, discussed the important aspects of the video, and then stopped the action (or even blanked it from the screen), the audience would have focused on the information she was presenting.

>> Presentation Graphics Guideline 4: Consider Alternatives to Bulleted Lists

Recently, there has been a move away from the default slide layouts in most presentation software. One recommendation is to use full-sentence headings on slides to help the audience understand and remember the information being presented; another is to combine text with graphics on slides when appropriate.²

>> Presentation Graphics Guideline 5: Use Colors Carefully

Colors can add flair to visuals. Use the following simple guidelines to make colors work for you:

- Have a good reason for using color (such as the need to highlight three different bars on a graph with three distinct colors).
- Be sure that a color contrasts with its background (e.g., yellow on white does not work well).
- Use no more than three or four colors in each graphic (to avoid a confused effect).

>> Presentation Graphics Guideline 6: Learn the Tools Available to You

Today, most presentations are created with presentation slide software, such as PowerPoint, but the defaults on these programs often do not follow the guidelines listed above. To create effective presentation graphics, you should learn to create and save customized templates for your presentations. Learn to use the master slide tools in your software to customize color schemes, backgrounds, and bullets. Consider incorporating your organization's logo into the master slide. Including information about the presentation, such as the date and location, can be useful for your future reference. Learn how to create and arrange text boxes and image boxes on individual slides, and how to insert hyperlinks to Web sites and sound or image files. Remember that all files related to your slide presentation need to be stored in the same folder on your computer or flash drive.

²M. Alley & K. A. Neeley. (2005). Rethinking the design of presentation slides: A case for sentences headlines and visual evidence. *Technical Communication*, 52(4), 417–426.

>> Presentation Graphics Guideline 7: Leave Graphics Up Long Enough

Because graphics reinforce text, they should be shown only while you address the particular point at hand. For example, reveal a graph just as you are saying, “As you can see from the graph, the projected revenue reaches a peak in 2013.” Then pause and leave the graph up a bit longer for the audience to absorb your point.

How long is too long? A graphic outlives its usefulness when it remains in sight after you have moved on to another topic. Listeners continue to study it and ignore what you are now saying. If you use a graphic once and plan to return to it, take it down after its first use and show it again later.

>> Presentation Graphics Guideline 8: Avoid Handouts

Because timing is so important in your use of speech graphics, handouts are usually a bad idea. Readers move through a handout at their own pace, rather than at the pace the speaker might prefer. Thus handouts cause you to lose the attention of your audience. Use them only if (1) no other visual will do, (2) your listener has requested them, or (3) you distribute them as reference material after you have finished talking.

>> Presentation Graphics Guideline 9: Maintain Eye Contact While Using Graphics

Do not stare at your visuals while you speak. Maintain control of listeners’ responses by looking back and forth from the visual to faces in the audience. To point to the graphic aid, use the hand closest to the visual. Using the opposite hand causes you to cross over your torso, forcing you to turn your neck and head away from the audience.

>> Presentation Graphics Guideline 10: Include All Graphics in Your Practice Sessions

Dry runs before the actual presentation should include every graphic you plan to use, in its final form. This is a good reason to prepare graphics as you prepare text, rather than as an afterthought. If you are going to be projecting images from a transparency or computer program, the projected image may appear different than the original image. Colors may look slightly different, and text and images that are clear on your computer screen or transparency may seem out of focus or too small for an audience looking at a screen. By previewing your graphics, you are able to fix them before your presentation. The goal is to use graphics you can be proud of. Never put yourself in the position of having to apologize for the quality of your graphic material. If an illustration is not up to the quality your audience would expect, do not use it.

You should also practice timing your graphics with your speech. Running through a final practice without graphics would be much like doing a dress rehearsal for a play without costumes and props—you would be leaving out parts that require the greatest degree of timing and orchestration. Practicing with graphics helps you improve transitions.

>> Presentation Graphics Guideline 11: Plan for Technology to Fail

Murphy’s Law always seems to apply when you use another person’s audiovisual equipment: Whatever can go wrong will, and at the worst possible moment. For example, a

new bulb burns out and there is no extra bulb in the equipment drawer; an extension cord is too short; the screen does not stay down; the client's computer doesn't read your file—many speakers have experienced these problems and more. Even if the equipment works, it often operates differently from what you are used to. The only sure way to put the odds in your favor is to carry your own equipment and set it up in advance.

However, most of us must rely on someone else's equipment at least some of the time. Following are a few ways to ward off disaster:

- Find out exactly who is responsible for providing the equipment and contact that person in advance.
- If you will be using a laptop or notebook computer to present your slides, ask about the projection technology that you will be using. Learn how to switch the image from your computer screen to the projecting equipment that you will be using.
- Have some easy-to-carry backup supplies in your car—an extension cord, an overhead projector bulb, large tablets, felt-tip markers, and chalk, for example.
- Bring handout versions of your visuals to use as a last resort.
- In short, you want to avoid putting yourself in the position of having to apologize. Plan well.

Presentation Graphics Guidelines

- Discover listener preferences
- Match the graphics to the content
- Keep the message simple
- Consider alternatives to bulleted lists
- Use colors carefully
- Learn the tools available to you
- Leave graphics up long enough
- Avoid handouts
- Maintain eye contact while using graphics
- Include all graphics in your practice sessions
- Plan for technology to fail

>>> Poster Guidelines

Poster sessions have long been a common feature of science and engineering conferences, and they have become popular ways to share the results of research in a wide range of professional and academic fields. Poster sessions are a regular part of conferences of professional organizations like the Society for Technical Communication and academic organizations like the Association of Teachers of Technical Writing. Many campuses are now using poster sessions as a way for students across campus to share their research, and the Council for Undergraduate Research sponsors regional and national conferences that feature poster sessions.

If you have participated in a science fair, you are already familiar with the basic setup of a poster session. In poster sessions like the one in Figure 15–2, a number of researchers display their posters, and other participants walk around the room from poster to poster, discussing research projects with the presenters. Posters offer a snapshot of the research project and are a good way to share preliminary results. The feedback from poster session audience members can be helpful to researchers. The following guidelines will help you design a poster that is informative and appropriate for the setting of a poster session.

>> Poster Guideline 1: Follow the Requirements of the Call for Posters

Many conferences include a Call for Posters as part of their Call for Papers (CFP) announcements. Read the announcement carefully and submit exactly the information that



■ **Figure 15-2** ■ 2010 Posters on the Hill

Source: Council for Undergraduate Research, www.cur.org.

ABC Format: Posters

- **ABSTRACT:** Research question and summary of theory that forms the basis for the study
- **BODY:** Methodology and discussion of results
- **CONCLUSION:** Summary of key findings or description of future work on the project

is requested. Once your poster is accepted for the conference, check all requirements for content, size, and materials for posters. You should also be given information about what materials the conference will make available (for example, easels and pushpins).

>> Poster Guideline 2: Follow the ABC Format for Research Posters

The ABC format for posters is similar to the ABC format for presenting research, which is discussed on page 268 in Chapter 9. The abstract of a poster should explain the research question that was studied, and it should identify any key theories that informed your research. The body should explain your research methodology and summarize your results. The conclusion of a research poster may either summarize conclusions of a completed study or outline the next steps in a study that is still in progress.

>> Poster Guideline 3: Design Your Poster for Ease of Reading

Poster sessions can include anywhere from a few posters to dozens of posters displayed in a room, and a conference may have dozens or hundreds of participants. Thus your poster needs to be easy to read from about three feet away and should contain no more information

than it takes about 10 minutes to read. To format your poster for ease of reading in this setting, you should clearly design your poster with blocks of information, formatted as follows:

- Center your title at the top of the poster, using a font size of 60 to 78 points.
- Center your name, your organization, and the event where the poster is being presented below the title in a slightly smaller font size.
- Use clear, informative headings (for example, “Stress Tolerances of Framing Materials” instead of “Findings”) for each section, in a font size of at least 50 points.
- Use a font size of at least 35 points for body text, and use lists and tables when possible to organize your information.
- Use graphs, charts, drawings, and photographs to illustrate your poster, as appropriate.
- Allow plenty of white space around poster sections. A common problem with early drafts of posters is too much text.

>> Poster Guideline 4: Include Acknowledgments as Appropriate

If your research project was completed as part of a class assignment, if it was funded by an outside source, or if a person or organization was particularly helpful with your project,

include an acknowledgment statement. If your project required approval from an Institutional Review Board (IRB—see Chapter 9), you should state that information. You should also include a brief bibliography of important sources, especially any that you cite on your poster.

>> **Poster Guideline 5: Prepare Handouts as Appropriate to the Setting**

Some conferences encourage poster session participants to include a handout for those attending the session. Handouts may include a complete bibliography and your contact information. If you are still seeking feedback through a survey or questionnaire, you can include information about how conference attendees can participate in your study. You may also want to have business cards printed up, in case someone wants your contact information, and don't be shy about asking for the business card of someone who may be a good resource for your project.

>> **Poster Guideline 6: Edit Carefully**

As with all other documents discussed in this book, you should edit your poster carefully. Remember that your audience may include potential employers or representatives of universities to which you may apply for graduate study, so you want to make a good impression.

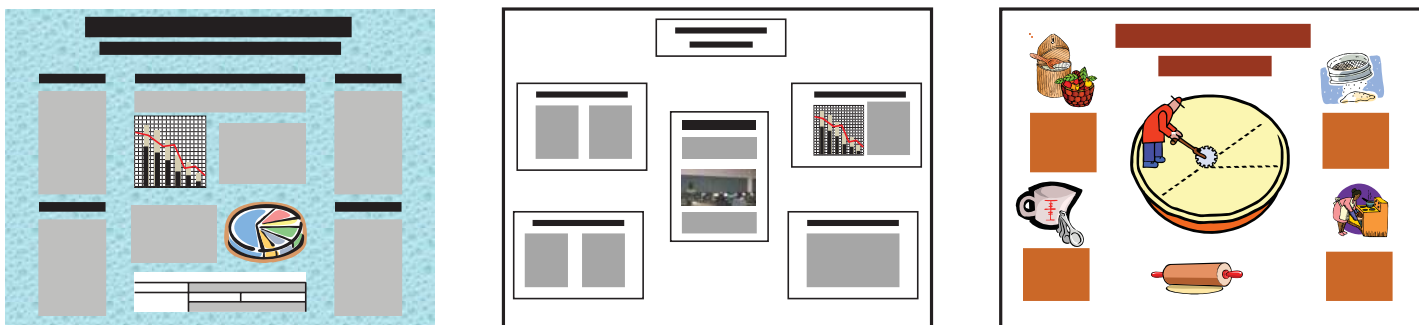
>> **Poster Guideline 7: Be Prepared to Discuss Your Research**

During a poster session, you will probably be asked to explain your research. Respond with enthusiasm and a clear understanding of your project. You may want to practice a brief summary of your research beforehand (like the elevator speech at the beginning of this chapter), but make sure that your responses do not sound memorized.

One easy way to create a poster is to use slide presentation software such as PowerPoint. If you have access to a poster printer (either in your organization or through a commercial quick-print center) you can format your slide to the appropriate size for the printer (usually about 32 inches by 40 inches). If you do not have access to a poster printer, you can still put your information on individual presentation slides and attach those slides to poster board. Figure 15–3 shows three possible ways to design a poster. The first design shows a poster that uses a traditional format with text boxes arranged in columns and that is printed on a single sheet of paper. The second poster is also fairly traditional in its format and uses individual sheets of paper attached to poster board. The third poster uses a more creative design, using baking as a visual and verbal metaphor for discussing results displayed in a pie chart.

Poster Guidelines

- Follow the requirements of the call for posters
- Follow the ABC format for research posters
- Design your poster for ease of reading
- Include acknowledgments as appropriate
- Prepare handouts as appropriate to the setting
- Edit carefully
- Be prepared to discuss your research



■ **Figure 15-3** ■ Sample research poster designs

>>> Overcoming Nervousness

The problem of nervousness deserves special mention because it is so common. Virtually everyone who gives speeches feels some degree of nervousness before “the event.” An instinctive fight-or-flight response kicks in for the many people who have an absolute dread of presentations. In fact, surveys have determined that most of us rate public speaking at the top of our list of fears, even above sickness and death! Given this common response, we consider the problem and offer suggestions for overcoming it.

Why Do We Fear Presentations?

Most of us feel comfortable with informal conversations, when we can voice our views to friends and indulge in impromptu exchanges. We are used to this type of casual presenting of our ideas. Formal presentations, however, put us into a more structured, more awkward, and thus more tense environment. Even if we know the audience is friendly and interested in our success, the formal context triggers nervousness that is sometimes difficult to control.

This nervous response is normal and, to some degree, useful. It gets you “up” for the speech. That adrenaline pumping through your body can generate a degree of enthusiasm that propels the presentation forward and creates a lively performance. Just as veteran actors admit to some nervousness helping improve their performance, excellent speakers usually can benefit from the same effect.

The problem occurs when nervousness felt before or during a speech becomes so overwhelming that it affects the quality of the presentation. Because sympathy is the last feeling a speaker wants the audience to have, it is worth considering some techniques to combat nervousness.

A Strategy for Staying Calm

As the cliché goes, do not try to eliminate butterflies before a presentation—just get them to fly in formation. In other words, it is best to acknowledge that a certain degree of

nervousness will always remain; then go about the business of getting it to work for you. Following are a few suggestions:

>> No Nerves Guideline 1: Know Your Speech

The most obvious suggestion is also the most important one. If you prepare your speech well, your command of the material helps conquer any queasiness you feel—particularly at the beginning of the speech, when nervousness is usually at its peak. Be so sure of the material that your listeners overlook any initial discomfort you may feel.

>> No Nerves Guideline 2: Prepare Yourself Physically

Your physical well-being before the speech can have a direct bearing on anxiety. More than ever before, most cultures understand the essential connection between mental and physical well-being. This connection suggests you should take the following precautions before your presentation:

- **Avoid caffeine or alcohol for at least several hours before you speak.** You do not need the additional jitters brought on by caffeine or the false sense of ease brought on by alcohol.
- **Eat a light and well-balanced meal within a few hours of speaking.** However, do not overdo it—particularly if a meal comes right before your speech. If you are convinced that any eating will increase your anxiety, wait to eat until after speaking.
- **Practice deep-breathing exercises before you speak.** Inhale and exhale slowly, making your body slow down to a pace you can control. If you can control your breathing, you can probably keep the butterflies flying in formation.
- **Exercise normally the same day of the presentation.** A good walk helps invigorate you and reduces nervousness; however, do not wear yourself out by exercising more than you would normally.

>> No Nerves Guideline 3: Picture Yourself Giving a Great Presentation

Many speakers become nervous because their imaginations are working overtime. They envision the kinds of failure that almost never occur. Instead, speakers should be constantly bombarding their psyches with images of success. Mentally take yourself through the following steps of the presentation:

- Arriving at the room
- Feeling comfortable at your chair
- Getting encouraging looks from your audience
- Giving an attention-getting introduction
- Presenting your supporting points with clarity and smoothness
- Ending with an effective wrap-up
- Fielding questions with confidence

Sometimes called *imaging*, this technique helps to program success into your thinking and to control negative feelings that pass through the minds of even the best speakers.

>> No Nerves Guideline 4: Arrange the Room as You Want It

To control your anxiety, assert some control over the physical environment as well. You need everything going for you if you are to feel at ease. Make sure that chairs are arranged to your satisfaction, that the lectern is positioned to your taste, that the lighting is adequate, and so on. These features of the setting can almost always be adjusted if you make the effort to ask. Again, it is a matter of your asserting control to increase your overall confidence.

>> No Nerves Guideline 5: Have a Glass of Water Nearby

Extreme thirst and a dry throat are physical symptoms of nervousness that can affect delivery. There is nothing to worry about as long as you have water available. Think about this need ahead of time so that you do not have to interrupt your presentation to pour a glass of water.



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>> No Nerves Guideline 6: Engage in Casual Banter Before the Speech

If you have the opportunity, chat with members of the audience before the speech. This ice-breaking technique reduces your nervousness and helps start your relationship with the audience.

>> No Nerves Guideline 7: Remember That You Are the Expert

As a final psyching up exercise before you speak, remind yourself that you have been invited or hired to speak on a topic about which you have useful knowledge. Your listeners want to hear what you have to say and are eager for you to provide useful information to them. So tell yourself, “I’m the expert here!”

>> No Nerves Guideline 8: Do Not Admit Nervousness to the Audience

No matter how anxious you may feel, never admit it to others. First of all, you do not want listeners to feel sorry for you—that is not an emotion that leads to a positive critique of your speech. Second, nervousness is almost never apparent to the audience. Your heart may be pounding, your knees may be shaking, and your throat may be dry, but few if any members of the audience can see these symptoms. Why draw attention to the problem by admitting to it? Third, you can best defeat initial anxiety by simply pushing right on through.

>> No Nerves Guideline 9: Slow Down

Some speakers who feel nervous tend to speed through their presentations. If you have prepared well and practiced the speech on an audio recording, you are not likely to let this happen. Having heard yourself on tape, you will be better able to sense that the pace

is too quick. As you speak, constantly remind yourself to maintain an appropriate pace. If you have had this problem before, you might even write “Slow down!” in the margin of your notes.

>> No Nerves Guideline 10: Join a Speaking Organization

The previous nine guidelines will help reduce your anxiety about a particular speech. To help solve the problem over the long term, however, consider joining an organization like Toastmasters International, which promotes the speaking skills of all its members. Like some other speech organizations, Toastmasters has chapters that meet at many companies and campuses. These meetings provide an excellent and supportive environment in which all members can refine their speaking skills.

No Nerves Guidelines

- Know your speech
- Prepare yourself physically
- Picture yourself giving a great presentation
- Arrange the room as you want it
- Have a glass of water nearby
- Engage in casual banter before the speech
- Remember that you are the expert
- Do not admit nervousness to the audience
- Slow down
- Join a speaking organization

>>> An Example of an M-Global Oral Presentation

Model 15–1 on pages 593–597 presents the text and visuals of a short presentation given by Kim Mason, an environmental expert for M-Global’s Atlanta office. She has been invited to speak at the monthly lunch meeting of an organization of building owners in the Atlanta region. The agreed-on topic is the problem of asbestos contamination.

The members of Kim’s audience have an obvious interest in the problem: They own buildings at risk. Yet they know little more about asbestos than that it is a health issue they must consider when they renovate. Kim’s job is to inform them and heighten their awareness. She must cover only the highlights, however, because the presentation will be followed by a detailed question-and-answer session. Although some of these owners have been and will be clients of M-Global, she has an ethical obligation to avoid promoting M-Global during her presentation.

>>> Chapter Summary

- Oral presentations are an important part of success in your career.
- A well-written presentation will be created with the audience in mind, will focus on a few main points, and will use the ABC format.
- Preparation for a speech should include creating an outline and practicing speaking clearly and directly to your audience.

- Eye contact and appropriate gestures and posture will help you connect with your audience.
- Presentation graphics should match your content, be attractive, and clarify your speech.
- Speakers are often expected to use presentation technology, but they should have a backup plan in case the technology fails.
- Poster sessions provide an excellent opportunity for students and professionals to share their research in a casual setting.
- Posters should follow the general organization for presenting research, but they should be visually interesting and designed for easy reading.
- At a poster session, researchers are expected to discuss their research with fellow conference participants.
- Speakers can help prevent nervousness by visualizing a great presentation.
- Speaking organizations can help you overcome nerves.
- Preparation for a speech includes arranging the room as you want, having a glass of water nearby, and engaging members of the audience in informal conversation.

>>> Learning Portfolio

Communication Challenge Ethics and the Technical Presentation

Carlos Santiago had been looking forward to attending his first international conference. The Association of Medical Technology invited him to speak at its annual meeting. Now, however, some of his research presents him with an ethical dilemma. This case study presents background on his invitation. It ends with questions and comments for discussion and an assignment for a written response to the Challenge.

An Opportunity in Caracas

Carlos Santiago works as an equipment development specialist in M-Global's San Francisco office. For two years he has been helping a large medical equipment firm, MedExcel, Inc., improve its C-2000 electrocardiograph. An electrocardiograph records electrical changes that occur during the human heartbeat. One of the most important pieces of equipment in diagnosing heart problems, it is made up of four main parts:

- Electrodes attached to the patient's body
- Electronics that convert and amplify the signal traveling from the electrodes to the computer
- A computer that interprets information provided by the electrodes
- An output screen and printer that provide information to the medical professional

In his work on the C-2000, Carlos (1) developed new electrodes that take extremely accurate readings, (2) designed a panel that is easier to read, and (3) created electronics that convert and amplify signals better than any model he has seen produced by any firm. These major refinements, as well as a host of smaller ones, created what he and MedExcel believe is the most user-friendly and accurate electrocardiograph on the market.

As a result, Carlos' work has been recognized in the industry. Next week he will fly from San Francisco to Caracas, Venezuela, to speak at the annual meeting of the Association of Medical Technology (AMT). MedExcel, which conveyed the invitation to him from the AMT, will be paying all his expenses for the eight-day trip. He has been asked to speak on "Advances in the Electrocardiograph." As you might expect, MedExcel expects that Carlos will showcase the C-2000 as an example of the most current technological advances.

A Late-Breaking Surprise

Everything has come together for Carlos. His client is happy, his branch manager is overjoyed that M-Global's small-equipment development team is gaining recognition in a major in-

dustry, and a high-visibility professional association is about to showcase his work. The public relations and marketing potential are significant, both for M-Global and for MedExcel.

Now the other shoe has dropped. Yesterday, just a week before the conference, Carlos was shocked to learn that Worldwide Medical, the main competitor of MedExcel, just came out with an updated version of its electrocardiograph, the HeartCart 300. From the article he reviewed in a weekly health care newspaper, the machine is competitive with the C-2000 in accuracy of electrode readings and in electronics. In addition, the panel pictured in the article appears to be a significant improvement over the previous HeartCart model. After reading the article, Carlos went to his computer to find the home page for Worldwide Medical on the Internet. From the additional information he found there, it appears the HeartCart 300 is competitive with the C-2000.

Carlos has mixed emotions about this finding. On the one hand, he is glad to see that another firm is investing research dollars in this technology, which is crucial to health care throughout the world. On the other hand, he is understandably concerned that his two years of work may become upstaged by the work of a competing company. For the sake of the investment his client has made in this research, he was hoping that the C-2000 would enjoy sales that would justify the research investment.

Questions and Comments for Discussion

More to the immediate point, Carlos is wondering what effect, if any, this new information should have on his presentation—a presentation that is being underwritten by a \$5,000 grant from MedExcel. Following are some questions for you to consider:

1. Do you think Carlos is obligated to revamp his presentation to include information about the HeartCart 300? If your answer is yes, explain exactly how he should proceed. If your answer is no, give your rationale.
2. Should his association with MedExcel have any bearing on his decision?
3. Should the manner by which Carlos received this new information have any effect on the answer to Question 1?
4. Give what you think would be the opinion of the AMT in response to Question 1.
5. Explain how your answer to Question 1 relates to the ethical guidelines for work discussed in Chapter 1 (see pages 13–15).

6. Generally, do you see any larger concern here in the relationship between professional associations and private enterprise? Explain your answer.

Write About It

Assume the role of Carlos. You feel that you must contact MedExcel about the HeartCart 300. Decide what you will

say. Will you ask questions? Make suggestions? Propose changes in your presentation? Write the text of an e-mail that you will send to Robert Morgan, the president of MedExcel. Remember that this is professional correspondence, so use appropriate tone. Provide the context, and include all of the information that Robert needs to give you an appropriate response.

Collaboration at Work Speeches You Have Heard

General Instructions

Each Collaboration at Work exercise applies strategies for working in teams to chapter topics. The exercise assumes you (1) have been divided into teams of about three to six students, (2) will use time inside or outside of class to complete the case, and (3) will produce an oral or written response. For guidelines about writing in teams, refer to Chapter 3.

Background for Assignment

Even if you have little experience as a public speaker, you already know a lot about what makes a good or bad speech because you have listened to so many presentations in your life, from informal lectures in a classroom to famous speeches by national figures. Every day you see or hear snippets of presentations in the media, so your exposure has been high. Considering all the visual input, you probably have developed preferences for certain features in presentations.

Team Assignment

In this exercise, you and your fellow team members will do the following:

1. Share anecdotes about good and bad presentations you have heard, focusing on criteria such as content, organization, delivery, graphics, and gestures.
2. Assemble a first list that includes features of speeches and characteristics of speakers that you consider worthy of modeling.
3. Assemble a second list that includes features of speeches and characteristics of speakers that you think should be avoided.

Share your list with the class, following your instructor's directions. You may be asked to use presentation software, overhead transparencies, or simply write your list on a large table or on a chalkboard. Be able to provide reasons why these features are positive or negative.

Assignments

Assignments can be completed either as individual exercises or as team projects, depending on the directions of your instructor. Your instructor will ask you to prepare a response that can be delivered as an oral presentation for discussion in class. Analyze the context of each Assignment by considering what you learned in Chapter 1 about the context of technical writing, and answer the following questions:

- What is the purpose of the document to be written?
- What result do you hope to achieve by writing it?
- Who are your readers and what do they want from your document?
- What method of organization is most useful?

1. Analysis: Speech Presented to an Audience

As directed by your instructor, attend a campus event that features a speaker, or find a recording of a live presentation on a Web site like www.ted.com. During the speech, take notes that will help you answer the following questions: What techniques does the speaker use to engage the audience? If the speech is given for a specific context (for example, a commencement speech), how does the speaker address that context? Do you think the speech is effective? Why or why not? Your instructor may show a speech to class for discussion, or you may be asked to write an analysis of two or three pages.

2. Analysis: Presentation Slides

On the Internet, find slides from a presentation in a commercial or government setting. Look for slides that explain a project or concept, not slides with advice about PowerPoint presentations. The easiest way to find these examples is to use the advanced search features of a search engine like Google, search for the word *presentation*, and look for results in one of the following formats: .pdf, .ppt, or .pptx. Analyze the slides using the guidelines in this chapter. What recommendations would you make for revising the slides? What assumptions can you make about the audience and context from the slides? Be clear about your reasons for these assumptions. Do the slides seem to be from an actual presentation, or do they seem to be a *publication of record*, designed primarily to prove that information has been presented to an audience or reader? How do you know? Your instructor may ask you to present your analysis to the class, or you may be asked to write your results in an essay of about five pages. If you are asked to write an essay, include images of some of the slides you are analyzing, as screen captures or as downloaded from the Web site. (See Chapter 13 for more on screen captures.)

3. Analysis: Posters at a Poster Session

If your campus sponsors a poster session where students present the results of their research, attend the event, study the posters, and choose one that you think is a good example of an effective poster. Make notes about the poster, the project, and the researcher. Consider asking permission to take a digital picture of the poster and the student or students who created it. In a two- or three-page essay, explain why you think the poster is a good model. Include the digital photo if you have one.

4. Analysis, M-Global Context: Asbestos Information Presentation

Analyze the presentation in Model 15–1 on pages 593–597. Consider the text of the speech located on the left-hand side of each page, the slides, and the slide notes that appear below each slide. Analyze the presentation using the guidelines in this chapter. Assume that you are one of Kim Mason's co-workers, and she wants your feedback before she gives her presentation next week. What strengths do you see in the presentation? What suggestions would you make for improvement? Be prepared to discuss your responses in class.

Follow these general guidelines for the Practice assignments:

- Print or design a letterhead when necessary.
- Use whatever letter, memo, or e-mail format your instructor requires.

- Invent addresses when necessary.
- Invent any extra information you may need for the correspondence, but do not change the information presented here.

5. Practice, M-Global Context: 2- to 3-Minute Presentation Based on M-Global Projects

Select one of the projects described in Model 12–6 on pages 472–478. Use information from the project and, if you wish, additional details you invent that could relate to the project. For this presentation, assume you are an M-Global marketing specialist talking to a group of potential clients in a meeting. They may hire M-Global for a similar project and thus want a summary of the job described in the project sheet.

6. Practice: 2- to 3-Minute Presentation Based on Your Academic Major

Give a presentation in which you discuss (a) your major field, (b) reasons for your interest in this major, and (c) specific career paths you may pursue. Assume your audience is a group of students with undecided majors who may want to select your major.

7. Practice: 5- to 6-Minute Presentation Based on a Short Report

Select any of the short written assignments in chapters that you have already completed. Prepare a presentation based on the report you have chosen. Assume that your main objective is to present the audience with the major highlights of the written report, which they have all read. Use at least one visual aid.

8. Practice: 5- to 6-Minute Presentation Based on a Proposal

Prepare a presentation based on one of the proposal assignments at the end of Chapter 12. Assume that your audience wants highlights of your written proposal, which they have read.

9. Practice: Research Poster

Create a poster for a topic that you researched for one of the assignments at the end of Chapter 9, or for another class. Your instructor may ask you to format your poster as individual sheets that can be arranged on poster board, or as a full-sized poster (if you have access to a poster printer on campus), or you may be asked to submit a digital version of your poster. If your campus sponsors a student research day, your instructor may ask you to share your poster in that forum.

10. Team Presentation

Prepare a presentation in teams assigned by your instructor. The presentation may be related to a collaborative writing assignment in an earlier chapter, or it may be done as a separate project. Review the Chapter 3 guidelines for collaborative work. Although related to writing, some of these suggestions apply to any team project.

Your instructor will set time limits for the entire presentation and perhaps for individual presentations. Make sure that your team's members move smoothly from one speech to the next; the individual presentations should work together for a unified effect.

? 11. Ethics Assignment

Suzanne Anthony, a prominent ecologist with M-Global's Atlanta office, has been asked to make a 30-minute speech to a public workshop on environmentalism, sponsored by SprawlStopper, a regional environmental action organization. She agrees to give the talk—for which she will receive an “honorarium” of \$500—on her area of expertise: the effects of unplanned growth on biological diversity of plant and animal species. Suzanne views the talk as a public service and has no knowledge of the sponsoring organization.

A few weeks before the speech, Suzanne's boss, Paul Finn, gets heartburn over his morning coffee as he reads an announcement about Suzanne's speech in the “Community Events” column of the local paper. Just yesterday, a large local builder, Action Homes, accepted his proposal for M-Global to complete environmental site assessments on all of Action Homes' construction sites for the next three years. Paul is aware that Action Home's has an ongoing court battle with SprawlStopper concerning Action Homes' desire to develop a large site adjacent to a Civil War national park north of Atlanta. Although M-Global is not now involved in the suit, Paul is worried that if Action Homes sees the name of an M-Global scientist associated with an event sponsored by SprawlStopper, Action Homes may have second thoughts about having chosen M-Global for its site work.

Do you think Paul should say something to Suzanne? If so, what should he say, and why should he say it? If not, why not? If you were in Suzanne's place, how would you respond to a suggestion by Paul that her speech might be inappropriate? Are there any similarities between the situation described here and the one characterized in this chapter's “Communication Challenge”?



12. International Communication Assignment

Prepare a team presentation that results from research your team does on the Internet concerning speech communication in a country outside the United States.

Option A: Retrieve information about one or more businesses or careers in a particular country. Once you have split up the team's initial tasks, conduct some of your business by e-mail, and then present the results of your investigation in a panel presentation to the class. For example, your topic could be the computer software industry in England, the tourist industry in Costa Rica, or the textile industry in Malaysia.

Option B: Retrieve information on subjects related to this chapter—for example, features of public speaking, business presentations, presentation graphics, and meeting management.



13. A.C.T. N.O.W. Assignment (Applying Communication To Nurture Our World)

For this assignment, use the same context as that described in the A.C.T. N.O.W. exercise in Chapter 13 (see page 524). Prepare the text of a short speech on the topic—with at least one presentation graphic—as if the speech is to be delivered to an audience with a strong interest in the topic. Assume the speech narrative is the basis for notes you develop for the speech. Alternatively, your instructor may ask that you prepare the speech notes and deliver the presentation either to the class or to another appropriate group.

Good evening. My name is Kim Mason, and I work for the asbestos abatement division of M-Global, Inc., in Atlanta. I've been asked to give a short presentation on the problem of asbestos and then to respond to your questions about the importance of removing it from buildings. I'll focus on three main reasons why you, as building owners, should be concerned about the asbestos problem: (NEXT SLIDE)

How to avoid asbestos contamination

Kim Mason, Environmental Engineer, M-Global, Inc., Atlanta

krmason@mglobal.com



Ryan McVay/Photodisc/Getty Images

1. To prevent future health problems of your tenants
2. To satisfy regulatory requirements of the government
3. To give yourself peace of mind for the future

Again, my comments will provide just an overview, serving as a basis for the question session that follows in a few minutes. (NEXT SLIDE)

By avoiding asbestos contamination, you can



Michael Matisse/
Digital Vision/
Getty Images

1. Prevent health problems
2. Satisfy regulatory requirements
3. Give yourself peace of mind

Three main reasons why building owners should be concerned about asbestos:

1. To prevent future health problems of your tenants.
2. To satisfy regulatory requirements of the government.
3. To give yourself peace of mind for the future.

Question: What is the most important reason you need to be concerned about asbestos?

Answer: The long-term health of the tenants, workers, and other people in buildings that contain asbestos. Research has clearly linked asbestos with a variety of diseases, including lung cancer, colon cancer, and asbestosis (a debilitating lung disease). Although this connection was first documented in the 1920s, it has been taken seriously only in the last few decades. Unfortunately, by that time asbestos had already been commonly used in many building materials that are part of many structures today.
(NEXT SLIDE)

What are some of the most common building products containing asbestos?

Asbestos was used in materials as varied as floor tiles, pipe wrap, roof felt, and insulation around heating systems.
(NEXT SLIDE)

Prevent future health problems of your tenants.



Craig Brewer/Photodisc/Getty Images

Most important reason to be concerned?

Long-term health of your tenants.

Asbestos linked to:

Lung cancer
Colon cancer

Asbestosis (debilitating lung disease)

Connection first documented in 1920s but taken seriously only in last few decades.

By this time, asbestos common in buildings.

Asbestos is found in

- Paper products
- Plastic products
- Insulating products



Chris Knapton/Photo Researchers, Inc.

Where will you find asbestos in buildings? [wait for response—discuss response]

[reveal list]

Plastic products: floor tile, coatings, sealants

Paper products: roof felt, gaskets, pipe wrap

Insulating products: sprayed coating, preformed pipe wrap, insulation board, boiler insulation

An abundant and naturally occurring mineral, asbestos was fashioned into construction materials through processes such as packing, weaving, and spraying. Its property of heat resistance, as well as its availability, was the main reason for such widespread use.

While still embedded in material, asbestos causes no real problems. However, when it deteriorates or is damaged, fibers may become airborne. In this state, they can enter the lungs and cause the health problems mentioned a minute ago. This risk prompted the Environmental Protection Agency in the mid-1970s to ban the use of certain asbestos products in most new construction. But today the decay and renovation of many asbestos-containing building materials may put many of our citizens at risk for years to come. (NEXT SLIDE)

After your concern about occupants' health, what's the next best reason to learn more about asbestos? It's the *law*.

Both the Occupational Safety and Health Administration (OSHA) and the Georgia Department of Natural Resources (DNR) require that you follow certain procedures when structures you own could endanger tenants and asbestos removal workers with contamination. For example, when a structure undergoes renovation that will involve any asbestos-containing material (ACM), the ACM must be removed by following approved engineering procedures. Also, the contaminated refuse must be disposed of in approved landfills. Considering the well-documented potential for health problems related to airborne asbestos, this legislative focus on asbestos contamination makes good sense. (NEXT SLIDE)



Gary Ombler/DK Images

Abundant, naturally occurring mineral
Fashioned into construction materials by packing, weaving, and spraying
Heat resistance, and availability, main reasons for widespread use
While embedded, asbestos causes no real problems.
When deteriorates/is damaged, fibers become airborne—enter lungs, cause health problems.
Mid-1970s—EPA banned use of certain asbestos products in most new construction.

Satisfy regulatory requirements of the government.

Occupational Safety and Health Administration (OSHA)

Georgia Department of Natural Resources (DNR)



U.S. Department of Energy

Next reason?

It's the law.

OSHA and Georgia DNR require following certain procedures w/structures you own—don't endanger tenants & asbestos removal workers with contamination.

When structure undergoes renovation involving ACM—follow engineering procedures.

Contaminated refuse—disposed of in approval landfills.

Both OSHA & DNR require removal of asbestos by licensed contractors.

Contractors assume liability only for what they have been told to remove.

By the way, both OSHA and DNR regulations require removal of asbestos by licensed contractors. These contractors, however, will assume liability only for what they have been told to remove. They may or may not have credentials and training in health and safety. Therefore, building owners should hire a firm with a professional who will (1) survey the building and present a professional report on the degree of asbestos contamination and (2) monitor the work of the contractor in removing the asbestos. By taking this approach, you as an owner stand a good chance of eliminating all problems with *your* asbestos. (NEXT SLIDE)

Yes, it is *your* asbestos. As owner of a building, you also legally own the asbestos associated with that building—*forever*. For example, if a tenant claims to have been exposed to asbestos because of your abatement activity and then brings a lawsuit, you must have documentation showing that you contracted to have the work performed in a “state-of-the-art” manner. If, as recommended, you have hired a qualified monitoring firm and a reputable contracting firm, liability will be focused on the contractor and the monitoring firm—*not* on you. (NEXT SLIDE)

Find a qualified asbestos removal professional.

1. The professional should survey the building and present a professional report on the degree of asbestos contamination.
2. The professional should monitor the work of the contractor.

By taking this approach, you stand a good chance of eliminating all problems with your asbestos.

It's *your* asbestos!

Yes, it is your asbestos!

As owner, you legally own the asbestos forever.

A tenant claims to have been exposed to asbestos because of abatement, brings lawsuit?

Have documentation showing you contracted to have work performed in “state-of-the-art” manner.

Liability will be on contractor & monitoring firm, not you

Which brings me to the last reason for concerning yourself with any potential asbestos problem: *peace of mind*. If you examine and then effectively deal with any asbestos contamination that exists in your buildings, you will sleep better at night. (NEXT SLIDE)

Give yourself peace of mind for the future.



James Lemass/Photolibrary

Last reason—Peace of mind
If you effectively deal w/asbestos contamination—
you will sleep better at night

For one thing, you will have done your level best to preserve the health of your tenants. For another, as previously noted, you will have shifted any potential liability from yourself to the professionals you hired to solve the problem—assuming you hired professionals. Your monitoring firm will have continuously documented the contractor’s operations and will have provided you with reports to keep in your files, in the event of later questions by lawyers or regulatory agencies. (NEXT SLIDE)

You benefit from safe asbestos removal because

- You have preserved the health of your tenants.
- You are no longer legally liable.
- You have helped your community.
- You have helped the environment.

Assuming you have hired professionals
Your monitoring firm will have continuously documented contractor’s operations; provided reports to keep in your files

In just these few minutes, I have given only highlights about asbestos. It poses a considerable challenge for all of us who own buildings or work in the abatement business. Yet the current diagnostic and cleanup methods are so sophisticated enough to suggest that this problem, over time, *will* be solved. Now I would be glad to answer questions.

Questions?



Gary Ombler/DK Images

These are highlights about asbestos.
Poses challenge for all who own buildings or work in abatement business.
Current diagnostic & cleanup methods sophisticated enough to suggest this problem will be solved over time.
Questions???